

# Son of Heaven

---

## Temple of Heaven Visitor Guide

Tiantan Park · Beijing · UNESCO World Heritage since 1998



*The Hall of Prayer for Good Harvests at first light*

# The Park

Covering 273 hectares in the Dongcheng district of Beijing, the Temple of Heaven park is larger than the Forbidden City. For nearly six centuries, from 1420 onward, the emperors of the Ming and Qing dynasties came here at the winter solstice to offer sacrifices and pray for good harvests, performing rites that affirmed their mandate as the Son of Heaven.

The park's plan encodes cosmology: its northern wall is round, its southern wall square, echoing the ancient belief that heaven is round and earth is square. A central axis runs north to south, joining the Circular Mound Altar, the Imperial Vault of Heaven and the Hall of Prayer for Good Harvests by the Danbi Bridge, a 360-metre raised causeway that rises gently toward the sky.

Beyond the ceremonial core, more than 3,500 ancient cypresses — some over six hundred years old — shade quiet gardens, echo walls and morning gatherings of Beijingers practising tai chi, calligraphy and song.



# Hall of Prayer for Good Harvests

*Qinian Dian · built 1420, rebuilt 1889*



*Triple eaves of lapis-blue glaze over white marble terraces*

The triple-eaved circular hall rises 38 metres on a three-tiered white marble terrace. Its deep blue glazed tiles mirror the sky; inside, 28 massive nanmu pillars — no nails, no crossbeams — carry the roof in a masterpiece of timber engineering. The four central dragon-well pillars stand for the seasons, the twelve inner pillars for the months, and the twelve outer pillars for the double-hours of the day. Beneath the gilded finial, the caisson ceiling coils with painted dragons and phoenixes.

# Imperial Vault of Heaven

*Huangqiongyu · the Echo Wall*



*The Echo Wall, tuned by six centuries of smooth brick*

Smaller and earlier in feeling, the Imperial Vault is a single-eaved circular hall that once housed the spirit tablets used in the solstice rites. It is ringed by the famous Echo Wall — 65 metres of perfectly smooth brickwork that carries a whisper along its curve from one side to the other. At its centre, the Triple Echo Stones return a single clap as three clear replies, an acoustic trick the court once read as heaven answering.

# Circular Mound Altar

*Huanqiu Tan · the altar of heaven itself*



*Nine-fold rings of marble around the Heaven's Heart Stone*

An open-air terrace of three white marble tiers, the Circular Mound is where the emperor knelt at the winter solstice. Everything here speaks in nines — the number of heaven. The flagstones of each tier, the balustrades and the steps all come in multiples of nine, and at the very centre lies the Heaven's Heart Stone: stand on it and your own voice returns to you, resonant and enlarged, as if the altar itself were listening.

# Visitor Information

---

|                        |                                                                                                   |
|------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Address</b>         | No. 1 Tiantan Road, Dongcheng District, Beijing                                                   |
| <b>Opening hours</b>   | Park 6:00–21:00 (Apr–Oct) / 6:30–21:00 (Nov–Mar);<br>monuments 8:00–17:00                         |
| <b>Tickets</b>         | Park entry approx. ¥10–15; through-ticket incl. all monuments<br>approx. ¥28–34                   |
| <b>Getting there</b>   | Metro Line 5 to Tiantan Dongmen (East Gate); Line 8 to<br>Tianqiao (West Gate)                    |
| <b>Best time</b>       | Early morning for cypress groves and local life; weekdays to<br>avoid crowds                      |
| <b>Suggested route</b> | South Gate → Circular Mound Altar → Imperial Vault → Danbi<br>Bridge → Hall of Prayer → East Gate |
| <b>Contact</b>         | <a href="mailto:visit@sonofheaven.com">visit@sonofheaven.com</a> · +86 10 6702 8866               |